as a story within India's nationalistic movement, the Ghadar movement still remains a footnote.' [6] Also, 'moving beyond the objective of liberating the country, they (Ghadarites) dreamed of creating in India a new social and political order (*nawan roop rachna Hind de samaj da*): secular, democratic and egalitarian. Their imagination of *deshbhakti* appeared to be different from the prevailing narrative of nationalism.' [7]

In 1914, Gurdit Singh, a Sikh businessman from Singapore, 'chartered on a time lease basis a Japanese ship Komagata Maru with the intention of becoming the first Sikh businessman operating what he visualized as Guru Nanak Steamship Company'. [8] His was partly a business venture, partly a mission to help 340 Sikhs, twenty-four Muslims and twelve Hindus immigrate to Canada and test the limits of Canadian exclusion laws, which prohibited the settlement of south Asians in Canada. Tickets were priced at a high of $100, but those who could not pay in advance were also taken on board with the promise that their relatives would pay for them on their arrival at Vancouver. The ship was renamed 'Guru Nanak Jahaz', and it flew the flag of Shri Guru Nanak Steamship Company.

When it berthed at the Vancouver harbour on 21 May 1914, the passengers, dressed in their best suits and ties, waited to disembark. But the conservative premier of British Columbia, Richard McBride, issued a categorical statement that they would not be allowed to disembark. On 7 July, the full bench of the Supreme Court of Canada gave a unanimous judgment that it had no powers to interfere in the decisions of the Department of Immigration and Colonization. Following this the Canadian government ordered the harbour tug Sea Lion to push the ship out on its homeward journey. Komagata Maru arrived in Calcutta on 26 September but was diverted to Buj Buj (27 km away from Calcutta, where the British intended to put the passengers on a train to Punjab).